Week 04 — Before You Come

100L · Semester 1 · File System & Terminal · Preparation: 35 minutes

Find it. Name it. Explain it.

This week you will organise files by typing instructions into a terminal. You will also launch an offline installer and check that a developer tool works. Class lasts **2 hours**; this preparation happens before class and is not graded.

> **Bring:** your laptop and charger if available, a notebook, a pen and these downloaded notes. No laptop? Tell the tutor so you can take a turn on a shared machine. No software purchase or online account is needed.

1. Be a file detective · 8 minutes

1. **(laptop or phone)** Open File Explorer, Finder or your phone's Files app. Choose a harmless file, such as downloaded class notes. Do not open private messages or records for this activity.
2. Find its full name and the folder containing it. If the app hides the ending, use its file information/details view. Record “hidden” if you cannot find it.
3. **(paper)** Record the file name, its ending (such as `.pdf`) and its containing folder. Predict what app would open it. Do not rename or delete anything yet.

Record: name _____ · ending _____ · folder _____ · app _____

No device? Use this fictional example: a folder named `revision` contains `week-03.pdf` and `questions.txt`. Identify which names describe files and which describes a folder.

2. Read with a question · 12 minutes

Read in this order; stop at the boundaries below. You do not need to install anything.

1. **MDN —** Dealing with files (6 min). Read “Best practices for naming files”. Skip the editor, website-building and HTML tasks. **Question:** Why is `class-notes.txt` easier to work with than a name with spaces and mixed case?
2. **MDN —** Command line crash course (6 min). Read “What does the terminal look like?” and “How do you access the terminal?”. **Question:** Which application would you open on your laptop? Windows users may choose built-in **PowerShell or Command Prompt (CMD)**; skip the optional WSL setup, installations, pipes, npm and all later exercises.

3. Give your partner directions · 10 minutes

On paper, draw a folder `school` containing `notes` and `pictures`. Put `map.png` inside `pictures`. Imagine you are standing in `notes`. Explain how to get to `map.png` using “up”, “into” and the names. Then start in `school` and give the directions again. What changed?

4. Recognise your starting screen · 5 minutes

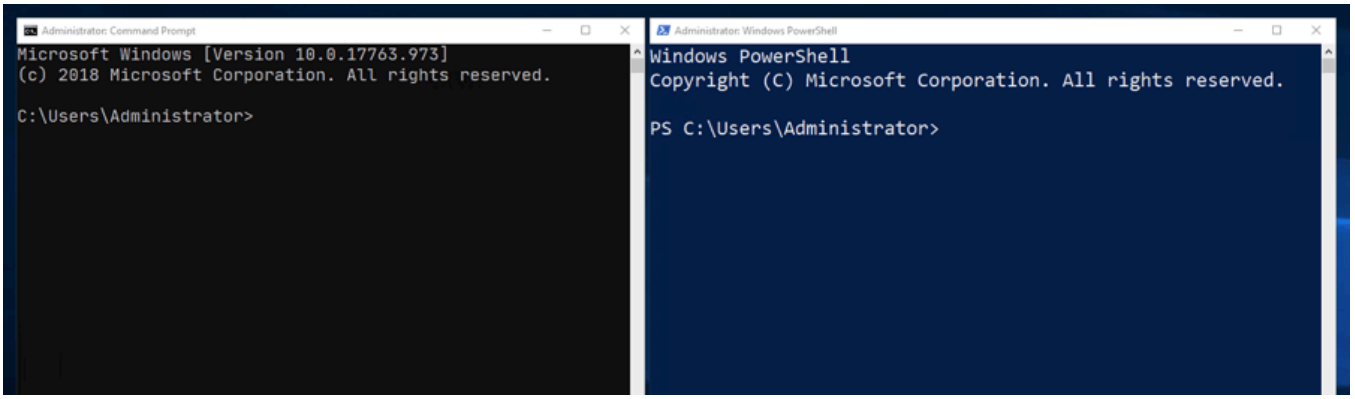


Figure 1. Windows examples from MDN contributors. Command Prompt is on the left; PowerShell is on the right. The reference shows administrator windows; open an ordinary, non-administrator window for class. Colours and version text can differ. Image unchanged; credit and licence below.

1. **(laptop)** Windows: search Start for **Windows PowerShell** or **Command Prompt**. macOS: open **Applications** → **Utilities** → **Terminal**. Linux: open **Terminal** from the application menu.
2. Find the line waiting for input. Do not type commands yet. Record **which shell** you opened. Windows Terminal can host either shell: check the tab's profile, not just the window's colour.
3. **(paper)** Record your operating system, whether you could open the terminal and one question you want to ask. Close the window when finished.

No laptop? Circle both prompts in Figure 1 and describe the difference in what is on the line before you type. You will use a shared computer in class.

> **Offline route:** Do Tasks 1, 3 and 4 using these pages. For Task 2, use this summary: a file holds data; a folder holds files or other folders; a path tells you where to find something. A terminal accepts typed commands. Your current folder determines where a relative path begins. You will practise all of this in class, without internet access.

Ready check

- I can distinguish a file from its folder.
- I have tried to find the terminal, or recorded that I need a shared device.
- I have brought my directions and one question. I have not used AI to answer the tasks.

Sources and image credit

- MDN contributors: the two articles linked in Task 2, checked 26 October 2026.
- Figure 1: original Windows terminal screenshot, from MDN's command-line article; unmodified, displayed at a smaller size. CC BY-SA 2.5, per MDN's content licence. This credit applies to the reused image; the activities are original.